

Guide 53 — Physical Therapist Assistant

Controlled English working master — Version 2.0

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What this work is

A physical therapist assistant (PTA) helps deliver physical therapy under the direction and supervision of a licensed physical therapist. In the United States, PTAs are regulated clinical support professionals who provide direct patient care as part of a physical therapist's plan of care. They may guide exercises, use approved therapeutic techniques and equipment, observe patient responses, document treatment, and report progress or concerns to the physical therapist.

A PTA is not the same as a physical therapist and is not the same as a physical therapist aide. A PTA does not independently diagnose a patient, create or change the physical therapy plan of care, or practice outside the authority allowed by state law, the supervising physical therapist, and employer policy. Physical therapist aides generally perform more indirect support tasks and do not have the same education or licensure pathway.

This guide is for career exploration and preparation. Licensing, certification, supervision, training, and scope rules vary by jurisdiction and can change. Always verify current requirements before enrolling, paying fees, accepting a job, or performing clinical work.

What a physical therapist assistant may do

Typical U.S. PTA duties can include:

- observing a patient before, during, and after treatment and reporting changes to the physical therapist;
- helping patients perform exercises that are part of the approved plan of care;
- carrying out approved therapeutic interventions such as stretching, gait and balance training, or other techniques within scope;
- using walkers, mobility devices, therapeutic equipment, or other approved tools;
- educating patients and family members about instructions already established within the plan of care;
- documenting treatment and patient response accurately;
- preparing or checking treatment areas and equipment according to policy;

- following infection-control, fall-prevention, transfer, lifting, and equipment-safety procedures; and
- escalating unexpected symptoms, deterioration, safety concerns, or questions that require the physical therapist or another licensed professional.

Exact duties depend on state law, the patient's plan of care, the supervising physical therapist, the employer, and the clinical setting.

What a PTA must not assume

Do not assume that PTA education permits you to:

- independently diagnose a medical or physiotherapy condition;
- create the initial physical therapy plan of care;
- change treatment goals or interventions without authority;
- perform tasks reserved to a physical therapist or another licensed professional;
- ignore supervision requirements;
- use a modality, device, transfer method, or clinical procedure for which you have not been trained and authorized; or
- present a foreign or unrelated credential as equivalent to a U.S. PTA license or another country's regulated professional title.

When scope is unclear, stop and verify with the supervising clinician and the applicable licensing authority.

Work settings and physical demands

PTAs work in settings such as outpatient rehabilitation clinics, hospitals, home healthcare, nursing facilities, physicians' offices, and other rehabilitation environments. Work may involve prolonged standing, repeated walking, kneeling, bending, transferring patients, guarding patients during movement, and handling equipment.

Because PTAs may help patients who have pain, weakness, balance problems, neurological conditions, post-surgical restrictions, or mobility limitations, there is meaningful risk of patient falls and worker musculoskeletal injury. Use approved body mechanics, transfer techniques, gait belts or assistive devices when indicated, and request assistance when a transfer or task exceeds safe limits.

Some employers require evenings, weekends, travel between patient locations, or home-health visits.

Skills employers value

Important skills include:

- careful observation and clinical reporting;
- following a plan of care and written procedures accurately;
- safe patient handling and mobility assistance;
- communication with patients, families, physical therapists, nurses, and other team members;
- empathy and patience with people who may be in pain, anxious, fatigued, or frustrated;
- accurate documentation;
- infection-control awareness;
- basic digital literacy for electronic health records and scheduling systems;
- recognizing when a condition or response is outside normal expectations; and
- professional boundaries, privacy, and ethical judgment.

PTAs also benefit from physical stamina, manual dexterity, time management, and the ability to explain instructions in clear everyday language without exceeding their scope.

Education and entry pathway — United States

The U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics states that physical therapist assistants entering the occupation typically need an associate degree from an accredited program and a license or certification. PTA programs commonly take about two years and include supervised clinical education.

Before paying for a program, verify its current accreditation status through the Commission on Accreditation in Physical Therapy Education (CAPTE). CAPTE is the recognized specialized accreditor for entry-level U.S. physical therapist and physical therapist assistant programs. CAPTE reports 379 accredited/candidacy PTA programs and 10,393 enrolled PTA students from 2025 annual accreditation reports.

A practical U.S. sequence is:

1. Review local PTA job postings and state licensing requirements.
2. Compare current CAPTE-accredited PTA programs, including tuition, fees, prerequisites, completion rates, clinical-placement expectations, and commute requirements.
3. Apply for financial aid and public workforce funding before taking private loans.
4. Complete the required academic and supervised clinical education.
5. Apply through the licensing authority in the jurisdiction where you intend to work.
6. Complete the National Physical Therapy Examination (NPTE) and any additional jurisdiction requirements when applicable.

7. Maintain continuing education, renewal, CPR/BLS, background-check, or other requirements required by the jurisdiction or employer.

Do not assume that graduation alone creates legal authority to work as a PTA.

Accreditation and program verification

CAPTE maintains a current directory of accredited PT and PTA programs. Use the directory directly rather than relying only on advertising by a school or a third-party education site.

CAPTE's accreditation standards were updated for 2026. A school saying that it is "physical therapy related" or that it prepares students for rehabilitation work does not mean that it is a CAPTE-accredited PTA program.

Before enrolling, confirm:

- the exact program's current CAPTE status;
- the credential awarded;
- whether the program meets the state licensing pathway you plan to use;
- total tuition and required fees;
- books, uniforms, equipment, background checks, immunization, CPR/BLS, travel, and clinical-placement costs;
- whether clinical placements can require commuting or schedule changes;
- refund and withdrawal policies; and
- whether the school provides transparent licensure-exam and completion information.

Licensure and the NPTE — United States

The Federation of State Boards of Physical Therapy (FSBPT) states that U.S. jurisdictions require a license or certification, depending on the jurisdiction, to work as a PTA. Each jurisdiction sets its own eligibility criteria.

The National Physical Therapy Examination is an important part of the licensing process. FSBPT states that the PTA examination assesses entry-level competence after graduation from an accredited program or an equivalent non-accredited program. The NPTE is only one component of licensure; a jurisdiction may impose additional requirements such as a jurisprudence examination, background check, age requirement, application documentation, fees, or continuing education.

As observed on August 19, 2026, FSBPT lists the NPTE registration price for a PTA candidate as **USD \$485**. Verify the current fee and your jurisdiction's eligibility before paying.

Income and outlook — United States official data

The U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics reports the following for physical therapist assistants:

- **Median annual wage, May 2024: USD \$65,510**
- **Lowest 10 percent: less than \$46,020**
- **Highest 10 percent: more than \$87,630**
- **Employment in 2024: about 111,500 PTA jobs**
- **Projected PTA employment growth, 2024-2034: 22%**

BLS reports these May 2024 median annual wages in major PTA industries:

- Home healthcare services: **\$77,540**
- Nursing care facilities: **\$75,800**
- Hospitals: **\$66,300**
- Offices of physicians: **\$62,170**
- Offices of physical, occupational and speech therapists and audiologists: **\$61,620**

These are national statistics. They are not promised starting salaries, and actual pay can differ substantially by location, experience, schedule, setting, union status, employer, and hours worked.

Current private salary estimate — keep separate from official data

Salary.com reported an average U.S. Physical Therapist Assistant salary of approximately **USD \$65,103 per year / \$31 per hour as of August 1, 2026**, with a stated 25th–75th percentile range of approximately **\$57,003–\$68,403**.

This is a private market estimate, not government wage data. Do not combine it with the BLS median or present it as a guaranteed salary.

Canada — related role, different system

Canada's Job Bank maps the title **physical therapist assistant (PTA)** to **NOC 32109 — Other technical occupations in therapy and assessment**. This occupational group includes technical therapy and assessment workers, some of whom assist physiotherapists or occupational therapists.

Job Bank's national summary describes the broad NOC group as usually requiring a college diploma, apprenticeship training of two or more years, or supervisory occupational experience. Because NOC 32109 includes multiple occupations, do not treat that general statement as a single national PTA licensing rule.

Verify the exact employer, province or territory, education program, and permissible duties. A U.S. PTA credential is not automatically a Canadian credential, and a Canadian assistant program is not automatically equivalent to a U.S. CAPTE-accredited PTA program.

Canada wage evidence

Job Bank reports national hourly wages for the PTA/NOC 32109 group, updated November 19, 2025:

- **Low: CAD \$17.62/hour**
- **Median: CAD \$26.85/hour**
- **High: CAD \$36.71/hour**

The source is Statistics Canada's Labour Force Survey for the 2023–2024 reference period. Job Bank also reports that **78.8%** of workers in NOC 32109 receive at least one non-wage benefit.

Job Bank reports varying provincial/territorial prospects and a **moderate risk of shortage** nationally for NOC 32109 over 2024–2033. These are group-level labour-market indicators, not guarantees for an individual title, school, or region.

Colombia — do not translate PTA into a professional physiotherapist credential

Colombia regulates **Fisioterapia** as a university-educated health profession under **Ley 528 de 1999**. The law regulates physiotherapy practice and professional registration and identifies functions that belong to the professional physiotherapist.

For that reason, a U.S. Physical Therapist Assistant should not be translated or represented as a Colombian **fisioterapeuta**. An assistant-level certificate, short course, vocational program, or foreign PTA credential does not automatically provide the authority to practice the Colombian profession of physiotherapy.

People interested in rehabilitation-related work in Colombia should distinguish among:

- the regulated university profession of physiotherapy;
- auxiliary or support occupations in health services;
- physical-activity and wellness training;

- occupational rehabilitation support; and
- other employer-specific support roles.

Use current Ministry of Health, Ministry of Education, SENA, employer, and professional-regulatory information to verify the exact pathway.

Colombia low-cost and public training exploration

SENA and Betowa are useful public starting points for training exploration. Current programs may include health-support, physical-activity, patient-care, occupational-safety, or rehabilitation-adjacent content depending on the intake and region. For example, SENA currently lists a **Tecnólogo en Actividad Física** program, but that program is not a U.S. PTA credential and is not the regulated Colombian physiotherapy profession.

Always verify what a program actually qualifies a graduate to do. Do not pay a private provider merely because its marketing uses words such as rehabilitation, therapy, physical therapy, assistant, technician, or certification.

Latin America and Caribbean pathways

The meaning of physiotherapy, rehabilitation technician, therapy assistant, kinesiology support, and related titles varies by country. OIT/Cinterfor provides a regional network of vocational-training institutions that can help identify national public training bodies.

Use the regional network as a locator, then verify locally:

- whether the occupation is regulated;
- the recognized professional or technical title;
- required education level;
- clinical supervision rules;
- registration or licensing requirements;
- public training availability;
- program recognition; and
- whether the role is actually comparable to the U.S. PTA occupation.

Avoid literal title translation when it changes legal meaning.

Free and low-cost training and funding — United States

WIOA and American Job Centers

CareerOneStop provides a WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder. If you may qualify for Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act training assistance, contact an American Job Center and verify whether the exact PTA program is eligible and whether you personally qualify.

WIOA eligibility is not automatic and an eligible program does not guarantee funding.

FAFSA and federal student aid

Federal Student Aid states that completing the FAFSA can provide access to federal grants such as Pell Grants, work-study funds, and federal student loans for eligible students at participating schools.

Complete aid applications before assuming that private loans are necessary. Compare the total cost after grants and scholarships, not just the advertised tuition.

Employer assistance

Ask hospitals, rehabilitation systems, nursing facilities, home-health organizations, and large therapy practices about benefits such as:

- tuition assistance;
- scholarship partnerships;
- clinical-placement support;
- CPR/BLS reimbursement;
- continuing-education reimbursement;
- paid onboarding;
- internal mobility from aide or support roles; and
- repayment conditions attached to employer education benefits.

Employer support is not guaranteed. Get repayment or service-commitment terms in writing before using a benefit.

Funding — Canada

Canada Student Grants and Loans help eligible students pay for postsecondary education through grants and repayable loans. Eligibility, designated-school status, and program rules depend on the student's province or territory and the specific school/program.

Current 2026 rules include changes affecting certain private for-profit schools, so verify designated-school eligibility before committing money.

Candidates should check both federal and provincial/territorial student aid and ask colleges about bursaries, accessibility supports, mature-student aid, and employer-sponsored education.

Apprenticeship and work-based learning

Do not market the U.S. PTA pathway as a shortcut apprenticeship. BLS documents the usual U.S. entry route as an accredited associate-degree

program with supervised clinical education followed by jurisdictional licensure or certification.

Supervised clinical education is genuine work-based learning, but it is part of the professional education pathway and is not automatically a Registered Apprenticeship.

Canada's broad NOC 32109 summary uses the phrase college or apprenticeship, but because the group includes multiple therapy occupations, that phrase does not establish a universal PTA apprenticeship route across Canada.

A practical 12-week exploration plan

Weeks 1-2: Review 15-20 local PTA postings. Record the state license, CPR/BLS, schedule, setting, experience, documentation system, and physical requirements employers repeatedly request.

Weeks 3-4: Identify CAPTE-accredited programs within a realistic commuting or relocation range. Compare total cost, prerequisites, clinical-placement structure, graduation requirements, and state eligibility.

Weeks 5-6: Review anatomy, medical terminology, basic kinesiology, infection prevention, communication, and safe body mechanics using free or low-cost study resources. Do not practice clinical techniques on patients without proper instruction and authorization.

Weeks 7-8: Complete FAFSA and investigate WIOA, scholarships, school aid, and employer education benefits. Build a written cost comparison for at least three programs if available.

Weeks 9-10: Speak with program admissions staff and, where possible, practicing PTAs or clinical employers. Ask about clinical placement travel, schedule constraints, background checks, immunizations, CPR/BLS, and licensing preparation.

Weeks 11-12: Confirm the state licensing pathway through the state board/FSBPT resources and decide whether the time, physical demands, clinical responsibility, cost, and expected local pay fit your situation.

Building experience before becoming a PTA

Depending on local law and employer needs, useful exposure may come from non-PTA positions such as:

- physical therapy aide;
- rehabilitation support worker;
- patient transporter;
- nursing assistant or patient-care support role;

- healthcare receptionist or scheduler;
- durable medical equipment support;
- fitness or wellness support within an appropriate non-clinical scope; or
- supervised volunteer work in healthcare or disability services.

Do not describe support work as licensed PTA experience when it was not.

Career progression

A PTA may develop experience in outpatient orthopedics, hospitals, home health, skilled nursing, geriatrics, neurological rehabilitation, pediatrics, or other settings where permitted. Advancement can also include clinical education support, lead or coordination duties, rehabilitation operations, or further education.

CAPTE lists PTA-to-PT bridge programs for PTAs interested in becoming physical therapists. Becoming a physical therapist requires a separate professional education and licensure pathway; PTA experience does not itself convert into PT licensure.

Patient safety and escalation

Patient safety takes priority over schedule or productivity. Follow the plan of care, supervision rules, facility procedures, and clinician instructions.

Stop and escalate according to protocol when you observe unexpected or worsening concerns such as:

- chest pain, severe shortness of breath, fainting, or acute cardiopulmonary symptoms;
- new neurological weakness, confusion, severe dizziness, or altered responsiveness;
- a fall or near fall;
- new or severe pain;
- unexpected swelling, wound, skin, or circulation concerns;
- an abnormal response to exercise or mobility;
- equipment failure;
- a transfer that cannot be completed safely; or
- any condition outside your training, authorization, or plan of care.

Follow emergency procedures when the situation requires them. This guide does not replace clinical training or employer emergency protocols.

Privacy and cybersecurity basics

PTAs may work with electronic health records, scheduling systems, patient portals, mobile devices, therapy equipment, and protected health information. Follow employer rules for:

- account access and multifactor authentication;
- passwords and credential sharing;
- locking screens and workstations;
- approved clinical documentation;
- secure messaging and file sharing;
- patient photographs or video;
- phishing and suspicious links;
- use of personal devices;
- removable media and connected equipment; and
- incident reporting.

Never use another person's login or share your credentials. Do not move patient data into an unapproved personal account or consumer application.

Using AI responsibly in this work

AI tools can help explain general terminology, generate non-sensitive study questions, organize a study plan, or help practice general interview questions. AI must **not** replace licensed clinical judgment, the physical therapist's plan of care, emergency procedures, official protocols, or jurisdiction-specific scope rules.

Do not paste identifiable patient information, clinical notes, images, dates of birth, medical record numbers, access credentials, employer-confidential material, or other protected information into a public AI service unless the employer has explicitly approved the tool and the use.

Verify AI-generated claims against current authoritative sources. A confident-looking answer can still be clinically or legally wrong.

Avoid scams and weak training offers

Be cautious when a school, recruiter, employer, or training seller:

- guarantees licensure, employment, or a specific salary;
- calls a program "accredited" without identifying the accreditor and exact program status;
- claims a short course substitutes for a CAPTE-accredited PTA program or state licensing process;
- hides total tuition, fees, clinical-placement costs, refund terms, or debt obligations;

- pressures you to enroll immediately;
- promises that a foreign credential automatically transfers across jurisdictions;
- asks you to pay for a job offer with gift cards, cryptocurrency, wire transfer, or unusual payment methods; or
- requests sensitive identity or banking data before you have independently verified the organization.

Verify program accreditation with CAPTE and licensing requirements with the relevant jurisdiction rather than relying on marketing claims.

When to pause before spending money

Pause enrollment when:

- the program's accreditation status is unclear;
- the school cannot explain licensing eligibility in the jurisdiction where you intend to work;
- clinical placements would be impractical because of distance, schedule, transportation, or family responsibilities;
- the physical demands do not fit your health or functional circumstances;
- you have not compared grants, WIOA, school aid, scholarships, and employer support;
- projected debt is high relative to realistic local wages; or
- you are being told that an assistant credential grants independent clinical authority.

Current sources

Official/public sources:

- U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics — Physical Therapist Assistants and Aides: [Source link](#)
- CAPTE — Directory of Programs: <https://www.capteonline.org/Programs/>
- CAPTE — About CAPTE: <https://www.capteonline.org/about-capte>
- CAPTE — Data and Research: [Source link](#)
- CAPTE — Accreditation Handbook: [Source link](#)
- FSBPT — State Licensure: [Source link](#)
- FSBPT — National Exam (NPTE): [Source link](#)
- FSBPT — Exam Registration and Payment: [Source link](#)
- CareerOneStop — WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder: [Source link](#)
- Federal Student Aid — FAFSA student steps: [Source link](#)

- Government of Canada Job Bank — PTA summary: [Source link](#)
- Government of Canada Job Bank — PTA description: [Source link](#)
- Government of Canada Job Bank — PTA requirements: [Source link](#)
- Government of Canada Job Bank — PTA wages: [Source link](#)
- Government of Canada Job Bank — PTA outlook: [Source link](#)
- Government of Canada — Student Grants and Loans: [Source link](#)
- Colombia SUIN Juriscol — Ley 528 de 1999: [Source link](#)
- Colombia Ministerio de Salud y Protección Social — Profesiones y ocupaciones: [Source link](#)
- SENA Observatorio — auxiliary health-services classification: [Source link](#)
- SENA Betowa — Actividad Física: [Source link](#)
- OIT/Cinterfor: <https://www.oitcinterfor.org/>
- OIT/Cinterfor institutional network: [Source link](#)

Supplementary non-government salary source:

- Salary.com — Physical Therapist Assistant (PTA) Salary: [Source link](#)

Source and review note

This controlled revision uses current-source research recorded on August 19, 2026. Licensing rules, exam fees, accreditation status, program availability, funding, wages, employer benefits, and clinical scope can change. Recheck the relevant official regulator, accreditor, employer, and training provider before acting.

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